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978-0-521-88666-6 - China's Struggle for Status: The Realignment of International Relations

Yong Deng

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China's Struggle for Status

At the end of the cold war, the People's Republic of China found itself in an international crisis, facing severe problems in both domestic politics and foreign policy. Nearly two decades later, Yong Deng provides an original account of China's remarkable rise from the periphery to the center stage of the post-cold war world. Deng examines how the once beleaguered country has adapted to, and proactively realigned, the international hierarchy, great-power politics, and its regional and global environment in order to carve out an international path within the globalized world. Creatively engaging with mainstream international relations theories and drawing extensively from original Chinese material, this is a well-grounded assessment of the promises and challenges of China's struggle to manage the interlacing of its domestic and international transitions and the interactive process between its rise and evolving world politics.

YONG DENG is a professor in the Department of Political Science at the United States Naval Academy. He has published widely on Asian international relations and Chinese foreign policy.

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YONG DENG

United States Naval Academy, Maryland



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Preface

The end of the cold war initially thrust China to the periphery of world politics; today, it is at center stage. The country's foreign policy path has markedly differed from those of its past and other great powers in history. As such, China's rise has not simply challenged the international status quo, but also challenged the conventional wisdom on international relations. Intense scholarly inquiries, media coverage, and public and policy debates have led to an explosive growth of knowledge about the various dimensions, dyadic relationships, and issues in China's ever expanding foreign relations. Left unclear, however, are vital questions concerning precisely how distinctive and uncertain is China's international trajectory: What is the nature of its discontent and revisionism regarding the world order? What can one expect of its behavior? And finally, how should the international community evaluate and react to the China challenge? These questions are difficult, but they must be confronted. Just as China's rise poses both dangers and opportunities, so does exploring the international politics surrounding it hold difficulties and promises for innovative thinking on how states relate to each other in the current world.

This book attempts to answer these questions by combining an overarching analytical approach and a multilevel empirical inquiry. My primary goal is not theory building, although I draw out implications pointing to new ideas on international relations in general. My main goal is to properly account for the dynamics and patterns of China's foreign relations. Analytically, as the book's title makes clear, I do not view the country's foreign policy in terms of horizontally arrayed states being locked in an unmitigated struggle for power, as posited by Hans Morgenthau and Kenneth Waltz. Instead, I focus on China's uphill struggle for status through adapting to, and realigning, the power, authority, and social structures of world politics. To devise an effective conceptual framework, I engage various theories in international relations and draw on insights from other fields without being limited

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to one particular approach; theories, after all, are proposed to help us better understand the world. Neither do I see China's foreign policy as derivative from a one-off strategic choice. Instead, I lay out the parameters that have embedded China's quest for great-power status within the world, paying particular attention to the interlacing of its leadership's domestic and international agendas, to the debate among the Chinese elites over their country's foreign course, and to the interactive process between China's rise and evolving world politics. Empirically, I uncover China's struggle by investigating its policy and diplomacy on issues ranging from the world order to great-power politics, to Asia and the developing world, and to Taiwan. The result, I hope, is a clear specification of the motivations, uncertainties, strengths, and weaknesses in China's foreign relations. I argue that China has sought change to the international status quo, but that it is equally determined to eschew the path of violent power transition; it is as determined to pursue power to address its vulnerabilities as it is confident and skillful in managing threat perception; it has put a premium on positive recognition, but it has not followed the path of liberal peace; and it has overall taken advantage of the opportunities that the open, globalized world has to offer, but it is doing so on its own terms. World politics has undergone major changes since the end of the cold war, many of which did not result from Beijing's initiative, but more often than not they seemed to have aligned well with China's policy adjustments on issues from the world order to Taiwan. Yet many questions have persisted regarding the country's domestic transition and the character of its power, and so have the real limits, difficulties, and uncertainties in its international environment. Unwilling to acknowledge the benefit of the openness and order underpinned by the U.S. hegemony, the Chinese elites have complained about what they perceived to be Western pressures and mistreatments. As their nation's power and influence grow, however, they may find it even harder to navigate the unfamiliar, rapidly evolving world politics while they struggle to define and manage China's new international role.

I started to work on some of the ideas in this book nearly a decade ago. Since I undertook the project, the studies of Chinese foreign relations have thrived both inside and outside China. I gained insights into the Chinese perspectives and debates in discussions with many Chinese colleagues as well as through their writings. My understanding of Chinese foreign relations has been enriched and stimulated by the

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vibrant community of scholars outside China. I am fortunate to have collaborated with many of them in two earlier volumes that I coedited: *In the Eyes of the Dragon* (1999) and *China Rising* (2004), as well as in other projects, and they have taught me much. Various parts of the book were presented at the American Political Science Association Annual Conference and at meetings of the International Studies Association and the American Association for Chinese Studies, as well as at two workshops funded by the Stanley Foundation, a symposium in honor of Professor Allen Whiting in Tucson, and in the Department of Government and Public Administration of the University of Hong Kong, School of International Studies of the Chinese Renmin University, School of International Service of American University, Watson Institute of Brown University, Fairbank Center of Harvard University, and St. Anthony College of Oxford University. I thank the following colleagues for inviting me to present my work at the various venues: Sherry Gray, Richard Hu, Iain Johnston, Seung-Ho Joo, Guoli Liu, Jonathan Pollack, Bob Ross, David Shambaugh, Song Xinning, Steve Tsang, Vincent Wang, Yong Wong-Lee, Zhang Xiaojin, and Quansheng Zhao. The International Studies Association and the Stanley Foundation funded two workshops that I codirected in the late 1990s that facilitated my exchange with fellow China scholars and prominent Chinese experts.

David Blainey, Lowell Dittmer, Iain Johnston, Bob Ross, Gilbert Rozman, Fei-ling Wang, and Allen Whiting read earlier versions of various chapters in the book and offered written critiques and advice. I also benefited from discussions with and suggestions by Tom Christensen, John Garver, Peter Gries, Stephanie T. Kleine-Ahlbrandt, Victor Koschmann, Barry O'Neil, Margaret Pearson, Helen Purkitt, Lucian Pye, Arthur Rachwald, Mark Selden, J. J. Suh, Robert Sutter, Michael Swaine, and William Zimmerman. The anonymous reviews for Cambridge University Press were most helpful in sharpening my thinking. The Naval Academy Faculty Research Council generously funded my field research in China as well as the research and writing of the book. I am grateful for all the assistance, but the views expressed in this book, as well as its weaknesses, are all mine.

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I dedicate the book to my wife, Aijin, and our children, Andrew and Ashley; they are the nucleus of my in-group. My wife has always supported me, despite her own busy career. My children have shown remarkable understanding of my preoccupation with the research and writing of this book in the last couple of years. Thanks to J. K. Rowling, my son thought being an author was cool, and my daughter was old enough to be fascinated with “chapter books.”